



Tesla giant battery makes \$1m

Tesla's 129 MWh Powerpack project in South Australia has made an estimated \$1 m AUD in the span of just a few days. <http://digit.in/tesla1mAUD>



Apple HomePod launches in Feb

The Apple HomePod, which is set to compete with the likes of Amazon Echo and Google home, is set to launch on February 9. <http://digit.in/aphomepodrd>

Huawei Honor 9 Lite 4 GB

Looks aren't everything

The Honor 9 Lite is an exquisitely crafted smartphone. There's

glass everywhere. Front, back, around the edges. It is so well made that it feels more like an alien artifact than a phone. The glass-enclosed design will remind you of the older Honor 8, but this one feels more compact thanks to the 5.6-inch Univisium display housed in a 6-inch body.

The display also didn't have the cool bluish tint that other Honor phones have. In fact, we found that the Honor 9 Lite's display has a more accurate white point. You can play around with the colour temperature though and Honor also gives you the option to dial down the resolution to 720p if required.

The display had a measured luminescence rating of 570 nits which is quite good for the price.

Although, because this is an IPS LCD panel, you won't get the deep contrasts on the Honor 9 Lite. As a result, while the brightness is enough to be legible under direct sunlight, content might seem a little bland.

Performance

The Honor 9 Lite is powered by the HiSilicon Kirin 659. Even weirder is the margin of difference the three phones had on benchmark tests. While there wasn't much separating the phones on AnTuTu or Geekbench 4, 3D Mark, which calculates graphical prowess of the phone, gave drastically low scores. After scratching our heads

for sometime, we figured it could be that the chipset's drivers are not optimised for Vulkan API

which is enabled by default on Android Oreo. Nevertheless, real world usage will show no difference. The phone did not slow down even after opening a lot of apps in one go. It takes around 35 seconds to boot which is commendable and the fingerprint sensor works blazingly fast. Overall, we felt the phone is quite fast for the price it retails for.

Camera

The highlight of the Honor 9 Lite is its Quad-camera setup.

Honor has done this over-kill before with the Honor 9i and now, it has trickled down the novelty to a price where dual cameras are just starting to come in. Under direct sunlight, the colours are somewhat faded and whitened out.

Under indoor lighting, the camera can reproduce vibrant and punchy colours, which is what Honor's cameras are famous for. Even then, we faced some difficulty to bring objects into focus. Low light shots are as you would expect from a mid-range phone. Noisy, and lacking in detail. Also, it takes significantly more time to focus and then some more time to process the photo after shooting. But the end result isn't as impressive.

To be honest, the camera is better than what phones at that price offer, but if you are buying the phone simply for the camera, it's better to explore other alternatives.



FEATURE.....	81
PERFORMANCE.....	82
VALUE.....	60
DESIGN.....	76

Battery

The Honor 9 Lite sports a 3,000 mAh battery which is just about enough to last you through the day. The phone lasted around 7 hours on PC Mark's battery test which is commendable. We also used the phone like a daily driver with generous amounts of social media browsing, playing YouTube videos, and browsing the web apart from half-an-hour of gaming and copious use of the camera to take photos.

The phone uses a micro-USB port to charge which is disappointing considering how the USB Type-C is fast becoming the convention across devices. There is support for fast charging and "smart battery saving" technology which essentially monitors active apps running in the background, manage screen-timeout and location settings to extend the battery life.

Verdict

The Honor 9 Lite will score full marks in terms of design but lose out on durability. The phone will again feel fast and smooth, but Honor's track record of providing timely updates is questionable. It may not have the attractive design of the Honor 9 Lite, but it more than makes up for it in terms of performance and camera quality. The higher variant of the Honor 9 Lite will go up against the Xiaomi Mi A1 and its own Honor 7X. Between the three, it will come down to the interface you are used to, the most and the build quality. 4GB of RAM should more than compensate for the heavily modified EMUI interface and take it at par with the Mi A1.

—Subhrojit Mallick

SPECIFICATIONS

SOC: HiSilicon Kirin 659 | GPU: Mali-T830 MP2 | OS: Android 8.0 (Oreo) | CARD SLOT: microSD (up to 256 GB) | SIZE: 5.65 inches | RESOLUTION: 1080 x 2160 pixels | CAMERA PRIMARY: Dual 13 MP + 2 MP | CAMERA SECONDARY: Dual 13 MP + 2 MP.

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